

ACCESSIBILITY CONFORMANCE REPORT

ADA & Section 508 Accessibility Audit

Internet Crime Complaint Center — complaint.ic3.gov
Online Complaint Form (7-Step)

AUDIT DATE	May 24, 2026
CONFORMANCE TARGET	WCAG 2.1 Level AA
REGULATORY BASIS	Section 508 of the Rehabilitation Act · ADA Title II
APPLICATION AUDITED	complaint.ic3.gov — the seven-step online complaint form
METHOD	Manual code & assistive-technology review (markup, ARIA, headings, error handling, focus)
REPORT STATUS	Final

About this report. This audit assesses the IC3 online complaint form — a complex, multi-step application built on the U.S. Web Design System (USWDS) — against WCAG 2.1 success criteria. Each finding is classified by severity, mapped to its governing criterion, and paired with a concrete remediation. Because the form is the destination of the complaint-filing workflow examined in earlier IC3 audits, it carries the highest real-world stakes: defects here can prevent an assistive-technology user from completing a submission at all.

Executive Summary

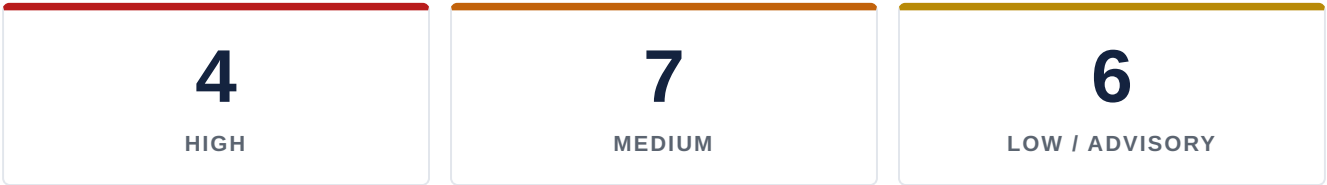
The IC3 complaint form has a strong structural foundation. Built on USWDS, it uses correct fieldset/legend grouping for radio questions, supplies an explicit `<label>` for every visible input, hides inactive steps from assistive technology, marks the active step with `aria-current="step"`, and gives its navigation buttons step context. These are the hallmarks of a form built with accessibility in mind.

However, the review identified **seventeen issues concentrated in the areas that matter most for a transactional form**: error handling, heading architecture, invalid ARIA, and validation communication. The form’s entire main content area lacks any heading structure; the 92 validation-error containers are not programmatically connected to their inputs and are not announced when they appear; the step indicator uses an invalid ARIA value; and all thirteen dialogs omit `aria-modal`. The remaining items concern grouping semantics, autocomplete support, required-field signaling, and several minor refinements.

Highest-priority barriers — Findings 2 and 4. Of all issues, the unannounced validation errors (Finding 2) and the non-modal dialogs (Finding 4) pose the most severe real-world risk. If a screen-reader user submits a step with invalid data and the error is never announced, they are left unable to understand why the submission was rejected or which fields need correction — a hard stop on the entire complaint process. These two should be remediated first.

All findings are remediable with targeted markup, ARIA, and minor scripting changes; none require redesigning the form flow. Several defects (the footer heading, the non-modal dialogs) recur from earlier IC3 pages and are best resolved in the shared templates so the fixes propagate site-wide.

Findings at a Glance



17 total findings across the seven-step form. Severity reflects user impact and likelihood of blocking task completion, not engineering effort — all items are rated low-to-moderate effort.

Severity Definitions

SEVERITY	MEANING
High	A defect that blocks or materially impairs access for assistive-technology or keyboard users, or that violates a Level A/AA criterion in a way likely to prevent form completion. Fix first.

Medium

A real barrier, ambiguity, or semantic mismatch that degrades the experience for affected users but generally has a workaround. Fix in the same remediation cycle.

Low / Advisory

A minor gap, consistency issue, or best-practice / AAA-level enhancement that improves clarity and robustness but is not a clear AA failure.

SECTION 2

Detailed Findings

Seven-step complaint form · 17 findings · 4 High · 7 Medium · 6 Low / Advisory

What's Working Well

- ✓ **Working skip link.** A skip link is present and its `#main-content` target exists.
- ✓ **Language declared.** `<html lang="en">` is set.
- ✓ **Correct fieldset/legend for radio groups.** Questions such as “Were you the one affected?” use `<fieldset><legend>` grouping with the question in the legend.
- ✓ **Explicit labels on every visible input.** Each text, email, tel, select, and textarea has a programmatic `<label for="...">` association.
- ✓ **Inactive steps hidden from AT.** `aria-hidden="true"` plus `display:none` correctly remove inactive steps from both the visual and accessibility layers.
- ✓ **Active step marked correctly.** The step indicator applies `aria-current="step"` to the active step.
- ✓ **Live character counters.** Textarea counters use `aria-live="polite"` to announce remaining characters.
- ✓ **Labeled help/definition triggers.** Definition-dialog buttons carry descriptive `aria-label`s and are keyboard accessible.
- ✓ **Labeled close buttons.** Dialog close icons use `aria-label="Close this window"` with `aria-hidden="true"` on the SVG.
- ✓ **Oriented navigation buttons.** Prev/next buttons include step context (“Next (step 2),” “Previous (step 1)”).
- ✓ **Accessible footer social icons.** Inline SVGs use `<title>` elements for their accessible names.
- ✓ **Custom validation.** The form uses custom validation rather than browser defaults, enabling tailored error messaging.

• High — Fix First

1 No page heading (`<h1>`) or meaningful headings in main content

Across all seven steps, the main content area contains no `<h1>`, `<h2>`, or `<h3>`. Each step relies on a `<fieldset><legend>` for its title — valid for grouping, but not surfaced as a heading. A user navigating by heading finds a completely flat main region. The only headings on the page are in the footer and dialogs, and the footer again misuses an `<h1>` for “FBI.”

Fix: Add an `<h1>` to main content (“IC3 Complaint Form” or the current step title). Promote each step’s section title to an `<h2>` (alongside or in place of the legend), and demote the footer “FBI” `<h1>` to `<h2>`.

WCAG 1.3.1 / 2.4.6

Effort: Low

2 Validation error containers are not linked to their inputs or announced

The form contains 92 `.val-error` containers, each with an `id` (e.g. `#Complainant_Name_error`) — but no input references its error via `aria-describedby`, and the containers carry no `role="alert"` or `aria-live`. When a step is submitted with invalid data, screen readers announce nothing: the user cannot tell their submission failed or why. Only tooltip hints are wired to `aria-describedby`, and those point to the hint, not the error.

Fix: Add `aria-describedby="[inputId]_error"` to every input with an error container, and add `aria-live="polite"` (or `role="alert"`) to each container. Where an input already references a tooltip, reference both: `aria-describedby="tooltip-id errorDiv-id"`.

WCAG 3.3.1 / 4.1.3

Effort: Medium

3 `aria-current="false"` is an invalid value on the step indicator

The seven-step indicator uses `<li role="button">` items. The active step correctly uses `aria-current="step"`, but steps 2–7 use `aria-current="false"` — not a valid token (valid values are `page`, `step`, `location`, `date`, `time`, `true`). Some screen readers announce it literally as “false”; the spec directs simply omitting the attribute when a step is not current.

Fix: Remove `aria-current` from all non-current step items; keep `aria-current="step"` only on the active step.

WCAG 4.1.2

Effort: Low

4 All thirteen dialogs are missing `aria-modal="true"`

The page has 13 dialogs (a Confirm Action dialog, 11 definition/help dialogs, and the Terms modal), each a `<div role="dialog">` — and none carry `aria-modal="true"`. Without it, NVDA and JAWS may let users navigate behind the open modal into content that should be inert. This is a site-wide pattern issue.

Fix: Add `aria-modal="true"` to every `role="dialog"` element, trap focus within each while open, and return focus to the triggering control on close.

WCAG 4.1.2

Effort: Low

• Medium — Should Fix

5 Several `<fieldset>` elements have no `<legend>`

At least 8 of the ~20+ fieldsets — including those wrapping Name, Business Name, Phone Number, and Email Address — lack a legend. Their inner inputs are labeled, but the fieldsets themselves are grouping elements with no accessible name, creating orphaned groupings in the accessibility tree.

Fix: Remove unnecessary nested fieldsets where a single `<label>` suffices, or add a `<legend>` (visually hidden with `usa-sr-only` if needed). Do not use `<fieldset>` as a styling container.

WCAG 1.3.1

Effort: Low

6 Step indicator `<ol>` has no accessible label

The `<ol class="usa-step-indicator__segments">` holding the seven steps has no `aria-label` or `aria-labelledby`. The parent `<div>` has `aria-label="progress"`, but that does not cascade to the list, so users encounter an unnamed ordered list.

Fix: Add `aria-label="Form progress"` (or similar) directly to the `<ol>`, or wrap the indicator in a `<nav aria-label="Form progress">`.

WCAG 1.3.1 / 2.4.6

Effort: Low

7 `<li role="button">` overrides list semantics; `inert` hides the visible label

Each step is an `<li>` with `role="button"` and `tabindex="0"`. Overriding the list-item role removes “item X of 7” context. The visible label sits in a `<span inert="inert">` (suppressed from AT) while an `usa-sr-only` span supplies the name — workable, but fragile if CSS fails.

Fix: Restructure as `<li><button>Step label</button></li>` and remove `inert` from the label span so list semantics and the visible label are preserved.

WCAG 4.1.2

Effort: Medium

8 “Remove” buttons provide no item context

The “Remove Transaction” and “Remove Subject” buttons have no `aria-label` indicating *which* item they remove. With multiple transactions or subjects present, a screen-reader user hears several identical “Remove” buttons with no way to tell them apart.

Fix: Add a descriptive, dynamically updated `aria-label` such as `aria-label="Remove Transaction #1"`.

WCAG 2.4.6 / 4.1.2

Effort: Low

9 Personal contact fields lack `autocomplete` attributes

The “Your Contact Information” fields (Name, Phone, Email, and address fields) have no `autocomplete` tokens. WCAG 1.3.5 requires recognized tokens on fields collecting personal data to support autofill for users with cognitive or motor disabilities.

Fix: Add `autocomplete="name"`, `tel`, `email`, `street-address`, and `postal-code` to the corresponding fields.

WCAG 1.3.5

Effort: Low

10 Required-field asterisk is announced as “asterisk Name”

Required fields are signaled with a red `*` placed as plain text inside labels and legends (e.g. `*Name:`, `*Were you the one affected...`). Screen readers read this as “asterisk Name colon.” Color is also the sole visual differentiator, and there is no `aria-required` (only the native `required`, which is acceptable).

Fix: Replace the literal asterisk with `<abbr title="required">*</abbr>` or a hidden `<span class="usa-sr-only"> (required)</span>` after the visible label text, so AT announces “Name (required).” Remove the `*` from legend text. Keep the native `required` attribute.

WCAG 1.3.1 / 3.3.2

Effort: Low

11 Live character counters are not linked to their textareas

The three textarea counters correctly use `aria-live="polite"`, but the live counter elements have no `id`, so they cannot be referenced by `aria-describedby`. The `IncidentDescription` textarea references `IncidentDescriptionCount`, but that ID belongs to a static duplicate label, not the live counter.

Fix: Give each live counter an `id` and append it to the corresponding textarea's `aria-describedby` (alongside any existing description).

WCAG 4.1.3

Effort: Low

• Low / Advisory — Consider Fixing

12 Step indicator is not exposed as a navigation landmark

The step indicator (`<div id="complaintStep" aria-label="progress">`) is the primary way to move between sections, yet it is neither a `<nav>` nor `role="navigation"`, so landmark navigation skips it.

Fix: Wrap the indicator in `<nav aria-label="Form progress">`, or change the outer `<div>` to `<nav>`.

WCAG 2.4.1

Effort: Low

13 “Confirm Action” dialog has no explanatory body text

The Confirm Action dialog (from “Remove Transaction/Subject”) offers only “Yes, proceed” and “No, cancel” with no body copy. A screen-reader user hears the heading and two choices with no statement of what is being confirmed.

Fix: Add descriptive body text (“Are you sure you want to remove this transaction? This cannot be undone.”) or give the confirm button a specific `aria-label="Yes, remove this transaction"`.

WCAG 3.3.2

Effort: Low

14 Help-link buttons are nested inside `<label>` elements

Several labels contain a help-icon link (e.g. the “Transaction Type:” label wraps an `<a role="button">` that opens a definition dialog). Nesting interactive elements inside a label is an anti-pattern — clicking the label should focus its input, but activating the nested control does something else, and some AT/browser combinations mishandle it.

Fix: Move help buttons immediately after the `</label>` ; the input's `aria-describedby` may reference the help control for context.

WCAG 4.1.2

Effort: Low

15 `<article>` is the wrong element for sequential form steps

Each step is an `<article>` , whose “independent, self-contained content” semantics are misleading for a sequential step — screen readers announce “article” on entry. Inactive steps are hidden via CSS + ARIA but do not also use the `hidden` attribute.

Fix: Use `<section aria-labelledby="[step-heading-id]">` (or a `<div role="group">` with `aria-labelledby`) per step, and add the `hidden` attribute to inactive steps in addition to the CSS/ARIA approach.

WCAG 1.3.1

Effort: Low

16 Duplicate `id="victimCountryError"` breaks ARIA targeting

Two elements share the id `victimCountryError` . Duplicate IDs are invalid and break `aria-describedby` resolution — the browser uses the first match and ignores the second, so one country error container can never be referenced correctly.

Fix: Make every error `id` unique. Since the Subject section can repeat, namespace them dynamically (e.g. `Subject_0_Country_error` , `Subject_1_Country_error`).

WCAG 4.1.1

Effort: Low

17 reCAPTCHA presents a potential barrier with no confirmed non-visual path

The final step uses Google reCAPTCHA v2 (checkbox). Its audio alternative is notoriously difficult, and the checkbox relies on behavioral analysis, with no confirmed fallback for users who cannot complete it. WCAG 1.1.1 requires a text alternative for non-text content used in authentication.

Fix: Consider reCAPTCHA v3 (invisible, score-based) or an alternative non-visual challenge. At minimum, verify the reCAPTCHA iframe carries a meaningful `title` for screen-reader users.

WCAG 1.1.1 / 2.1.1

Effort: Medium

SECTION 3

Prioritized Remediation Roadmap

Findings are sequenced by user impact. Within Phase 1, address Findings 2 and 4 first — unannounced errors and non-modal dialogs are the barriers most likely to block a submission outright. The footer heading and dialog patterns recur from earlier IC3 pages; fixing them in shared templates corrects the whole property at once. Nearly all items are low-to-moderate effort.

Phase 1 — High (fix first)

ID	FINDING	WCAG	EFFORT
2	Link error containers to inputs and announce them	3.3.1 / 4.1.3	Medium
4	Add <code>aria-modal</code> + focus management to all dialogs	4.1.2	Low
1	Add an <code><h1></code> and a proper heading outline	1.3.1 / 2.4.6	Low
3	Remove invalid <code>aria-current="false"</code> values	4.1.2	Low

Phase 2 — Medium

ID	FINDING	WCAG	EFFORT
5	Add legends to (or remove) orphaned fieldsets	1.3.1	Low
6	Give the step-indicator list an accessible label	1.3.1 / 2.4.6	Low
7	Use real buttons in list items; drop <code>inert</code>	4.1.2	Medium
8	Add item context to “Remove” buttons	2.4.6 / 4.1.2	Low
9	Add <code>autocomplete</code> to personal contact fields	1.3.5	Low
10	Make the required-field marker screen-reader friendly	1.3.1 / 3.3.2	Low
11	Link live character counters to their textareas	4.1.3	Low

Phase 3 — Low / Advisory

ID	FINDING	WCAG	EFFORT
12	Expose the step indicator as a <code><nav></code> landmark	2.4.1	Low
13	Add explanatory body text to the Confirm dialog	3.3.2	Low

14	Move help buttons out of <code><label></code> elements	4.1.2	Low
15	Replace <code><article></code> step panels with sections/groups	1.3.1	Low
16	Resolve the duplicate <code>victimCountryError</code> id	4.1.1	Low
17	Provide an accessible CAPTCHA path	1.1.1 / 2.1.1	Medium

SECTION 4

Ongoing Testing Program

A transactional form demands testing of the full submission path, not just static markup. Pair automated scanning with manual, end-to-end runs that deliberately trigger validation, and verify shared-component fixes across the rest of the property.

LAYER	RECOMMENDED PRACTICE
Error-path testing	Submit each step with invalid and missing data using NVDA and VoiceOver; confirm every error is announced and that focus moves to the first invalid field. This is the single most important test for this form.
Automated scanning	Run axe DevTools, WAVE, or axe-core in CI on every step state — including the post-validation (error-visible) state, which static scans often miss.
Keyboard & focus	Complete the entire seven-step flow by keyboard alone: step navigation, add/remove transaction and subject, every dialog open/close with focus trap and return, and final submission.
Screen-reader walkthrough	Verify the corrected heading outline, the step indicator's "item X of 7" context, dialog announcements, and live character-counter and error feedback.
Template-level verification	Findings 1 and 4 touch shared header/footer/dialog templates — re-test representative pages to confirm fixes propagate site-wide.

Scope & disclaimer. This report reflects a point-in-time review of the IC3 online complaint form as observed on the audit date. It does not constitute legal advice or a certification of compliance. WCAG conformance is determined per page and per process; remediating the findings herein advances — but does not by itself guarantee — full WCAG 2.1 AA, Section 508, or ADA Title II conformance. Because this is a multi-step process, re-test the complete submission path after remediation, including all validation and confirmation states.